

"EACH ONE SHOULD USE WHATEVER GIFT HE HAS RECEIVED TO SERVE OTHERS."—**1 PETER 4:10**

SUPPORT LEADERS

The people behind the welcome, care, and connection

Support Leader Handbook · 2026–2027

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YOU BELONG IN THIS MISSION

WELCOME, SUPPORT LEADER

We are so glad you are here! Every week, students walk into our ministries carrying different stories, questions, worries, and hopes. Some are excited to be here. Some are giving church a chance for the very first time. All of them matter to God.

Before a student ever joins a group or hears a message, someone opens a door, learns a name, helps them find their place, notices a need, protects the environment or prays for what God might do. **That someone might be you.**

> Support Leaders are not simply helping ministry happen. **You are doing ministry.**

Your faithfulness helps create the kind of environment where students can encounter Jesus and build relationships that last. You are part of one Student Ministry team. We are so grateful for you, and we want you to feel confident about why we serve, what your role makes possible and how to serve well.

THANK YOU!
YOUR STUDENT MINISTRY TEAM

01

SECTION 01

THE MISSION

Why we exist—different assignments, same mission.

WHY WE EXIST

SOUTHEAST CHRISTIAN CHURCH · MISSION

Connecting people to Jesus and to one another.

Every part of Southeast Students exists to support that mission. It is rooted in the Great Commandment and the Great Commission: love God, love people, and make disciples.

THE GREAT COMMANDMENT

Matthew 22:37–39

"Love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind. ... And the second is like it: Love your neighbor as yourself."

THE GREAT COMMISSION

Matthew 28:19–20

"Therefore go and make disciples of all nations ... And surely I am with you always, to the very end of the age."

Group Leaders live out this mission by building consistent relationships and discipling students. **Support Leaders** live it out by helping students feel welcomed, connected, safe and cared for. **Different assignments. Same mission.**

FOUR QUESTIONS

Four questions for every leader:

01 **How am I connecting to Jesus?**

Your relationship with Jesus matters more than the task you complete. Serve from time with Him, not as a substitute for time with Him.

02 **How am I connecting to one another?**

Ministry is a team effort. Know the people you serve with, encourage them, and build relationships that extend beyond your assignment.

03 **How am I connecting people to Jesus?**

A warm welcome, a calm response or an offered prayer can help remove an obstacle between a student and their next step toward Jesus.

04 **How am I connecting people to one another?**

Belonging often opens the door to deeper connection. Notice the student who is standing alone and help them find a person, a group, or a place to belong.

THE HEART BEHIND SUPPORT

ONE BODY, MANY PARTS

1 Corinthians 12:27

"Now you are the body of Christ, and each one of you is a part of it."

In 1 Corinthians 12, Paul describes one body with many parts. No part gets all the attention; every part matters.

The person leading a group and the person running check-in have different responsibilities, but both can help one student take a step closer to Jesus.

REMEMBER **WE DON'T JUST FILL POSITIONS. WE SERVE PEOPLE.**

02

SECTION 02

YOUR ROLE

What Support Leaders make possible.

3 WINS FOR SUPPORT LEADERS

THREE WINS

You may never teach a lesson or lead a small group. But the way you serve can shape whether a student feels comfortable enough to stay, connected enough to return and supported enough to take a next step.

01 **Students are seen and welcomed.**

A student is greeted, helped and treated like they matter...not like another name in a line. First impressions can become the beginning of belonging.

02 **Students are safe and cared for.**

Our spaces are attentive, orderly and responsive. We notice what is happening, honor boundaries, and involve the right people when a need arises.

03 **Students have room to connect with Jesus and others.**

When practical needs are met and distractions are addressed, students, Group Leaders and staff can focus on relationships, worship and discipleship. Prayer covers every part of the night.

WHERE YOU SERVE

TEAM

FIRST IMPRESSIONS

- **Check-In:** Help students and families navigate the approved check-in process and get where they need to go.
- **Connections:** Look for new or disconnected students and help them connect with a Group Leader, staff member, or next step.
- **Snack Bar:** Offer warm, orderly hospitality through food and conversation while following campus procedures.

TEAM

SECURITY

- Help maintain an attentive, welcoming environment through the assigned safety role, established procedures, and close communication with staff and designated security personnel.

TEAM

PRAYER TEAM

- Pray intentionally for students, leaders, families, staff and the movement of God. Be available to pray with people when appropriate and connect significant care needs to ministry staff.

03

SECTION 03

SERVING WELL

Behind the scenes, every week. Prepare, pay attention and follow through.

EVERY SUPPORT LEADER

WHAT WE ASK

01 **Be faithful.**

Honor your serving commitment and communicate early when you cannot serve.

02 **Be ready.**

Arrive at your campus's designated time, know your assignment, and ask what you need to know before students arrive.

03 **Be present.**

Look up, engage people, and stay attentive instead of waiting for someone to tell you what to do.

04 **Be a teammate.**

Support Group Leaders, other Support Leaders, and staff. No task is beneath us.

05 **Model the way.**

Represent Jesus through your words, attitude, relationships, and choices.

06 **Ask for help.**

You are not expected to have every answer or solve every situation yourself.

A GOOD NIGHT **is not just "Did I complete my task?" It is also "Did I help someone take a step toward Jesus or toward community?"**

EVERY WEEK

THE RHYTHM OF A MINISTRY NIGHT

BEFORE

Prepare the space and your heart.

Arrive at your assigned time. Check in with your team lead or staff contact. Learn about special events, changes, or needs. Make sure your station is ready. Pray for the students and families who will walk through the doors.

DURING

Stay available to people.

Do your assigned job with excellence, but remember the person in front of you is more important than the process. Look for students who seem new, overwhelmed, alone or unsure of where to go. Stay in your assigned area unless your team lead directs otherwise.

AFTER

Leave the ministry stronger.

Finish assigned closing tasks, pass along any follow-up needs and communicate concerns to the right staff member. Make sure the next team has what it needs.

FIRST IMPRESSIONS

CHECK-IN

YOUR GOAL

Help every student begin the night with clarity, care, and confidence.

- **Offer a genuine greeting.** A calm, friendly welcome matters even when the line is long.
- Learn and follow the campus-approved check-in and attendance process; do not create unofficial shortcuts.
- Help new students know where to go next. When unsure, connect them with the designated Team Leader or Connections Leader.
- Protect student and family information. Keep screens, printed lists and conversations appropriately private.
- If a registration, pickup, attendance or access issue does not seem right, involve the designated Team Leader or staff member instead of guessing.

A SMALL WIN ***"You're in the right place. Let me help you get checked in."***

CONNECTIONS

YOUR GOAL

Help people move from arriving to belonging.

- Look for the first-time student, the student standing alone or the parent who seems unsure.
- Introduce yourself, learn names and ask simple questions before giving directions.
- Help students make a real connection with the appropriate Group Leader or Team Leader, rather than just pointing down a hallway.
- Pay attention to students who have visited before but still seem disconnected.
- Share relevant follow-up needs with the Team Leader through the approved process; do not independently collect or distribute student contact information.

A SMALL WIN ***"Have you met your leaders yet? I'd love to introduce you."***

FIRST IMPRESSIONS

SNACK BAR

YOUR GOAL

Turn a practical service into a welcoming point of connection.

- Prepare, serve, handle payments if applicable and clean up according to your campus's procedures.
- Be warm and attentive; a short interaction can make a student feel known.
- Keep stations clean and orderly and follow food safety procedures (wearing gloves while serving food, etc.).
- Look for opportunities to help rather than allow the station to become a distraction from students.

A SMALL WIN ***"Good to see you back! How has your week been?"***

SUPPORT TEAM

SECURITY

YOUR GOAL

Help provide an environment where students and leaders can focus on ministry because concerns are noticed and handled appropriately.

- Know your assigned area, responsibilities, communication method, and reporting contact.
- Stay observant and approachable; pay attention to entrances, transitions and anything outside the usual pattern.
- Follow established campus and church security procedures. Do not invent your own response or investigate concerning situations independently.
- Communicate concerns promptly and discreetly to designated security personnel and/or ministry staff.
- During an emergency, follow the approved emergency plan and the direction of authorized responders.

A SMALL WIN

A concern is recognized early, shared quickly and handled by the right people.

SUPPORT TEAM

PRAYER TEAM

YOUR GOAL

Intentionally cover the ministry in prayer and help people remember that God is at work.

- Pray before, during, and after ministry for students, Group Leaders, Support Leaders, families, and staff.
- Pray specifically for students who are new, hurting, disconnected or exploring faith, using only information appropriately shared with your team.
- When someone requests prayer: listen with care, ask what they would like prayer for and pray simply and sincerely.
- Respect personal boundaries and ministry guidelines; do not pressure someone to share, respond, or accept physical contact.
- If a conversation raises a significant pastoral or safety concern, involve ministry staff rather than trying to carry it alone.

A SMALL WIN ***"Would it be okay if I prayed with you?"***

WHEN THE UNEXPECTED HAPPENS

01 **A student cannot find their group.**

Stay with the student as appropriate and connect them to the Connections Leader or Team Leader who can help.

02 **A parent has a question you cannot answer.**

Thank them for asking and introduce them to the Team Leader responsible for that decision.

03 **A student shares something concerning.**

Listen without making promises of secrecy. Bring in the appropriate staff member promptly, following established safety and reporting procedures.

04 **Something seems unsafe.**

Follow your campus's safety communication and emergency procedures right away. You do not need to determine whether a concern is serious enough on your own.

REMEMBER **Your job is to notice, care, connect, and communicate...not to fix everything.**

BE THE TEAMMATE YOU WISH YOU HAD

01 **Communicate early and clearly**

Especially if you cannot serve or something has changed.

02 **Assume the best**

Ask questions, and speak directly and kindly.

03 **Take responsibility**

Own your assignment and stay willing to help where you are needed.

04 **Protect trust**

Share sensitive student information only with appropriate ministry personnel who need it.

05 **Celebrate**

Celebrate what God is doing in other roles, not only the part you can see.

04

SECTION 04

THE TEAM

Who you serve alongside—one team serving one mission.

THE TEAM

ONE MINISTRY, DIFFERENT ROLES

Student Ministry is not made up of people working separate jobs. It is one team serving one mission. When we work together, students experience consistent care from the parking lot to the group room and back out the door.

STUDENT MINISTRY STAFF

- Equip volunteers, clarify ministry direction, make ministry decisions, coordinate follow-up, and provide pastoral leadership.
- Connect Support Leaders, Group Leaders, and campus teams when a situation requires additional care.

GROUP LEADERS

- Build consistent relationships with students through group, biblical discussion, discipleship, and ongoing care.

SUPPORT LEADERS

- Make space for ministry through hospitality, connection, prayer, and attentive service.
- Often notice needs first and help the right teammate respond.

CAMPUS SECURITY & PARTNERS

- Provide specialized oversight or responses according to the campus's approved processes. Support Leaders serving in security coordinate with them rather than acting independently.

HOW A GREAT HANDOFF WORKS

NOTICE

A ninth grader is standing alone and says they do not know anybody.

LISTEN

"I'm glad you came. Is this your first time?"

CONNECT

Walk with them to the right leader or staff member and make an introduction.

FOLLOW THROUGH

Let the appropriate leader know what might help the student feel welcomed next week.

The same principle applies to a concerned parent, a student requesting prayer, or a safety issue. Don't leave someone with only a direction when you can offer an appropriate connection.

WHAT YOU CAN EXPECT FROM STAFF

Staff should help you understand your assignment, connect you to the right team, provide role-specific training and ministry updates, and tell you where to bring questions or concerns. If you have not received the training or information you need, please ask before serving independently.

Same mission across every campus. Local processes may differ. Follow your campus's current instructions for team assignments, communications, student supervision, security, and emergencies.

05

SECTION 05

FURTHER RESOURCES

Help along the way. You don't need to know everything—just when to ask, where to go, and how to hand off a need.

A SIMPLE CONVERSATION GUIDE



GREEN LIGHT

"Care and connect."

Everyday questions, nerves about joining a group, ordinary friendship challenges, or requests for prayer can often begin with a warm conversation. Listen, encourage, and help the student connect with a Group Leader or staff member when helpful.

YELLOW LIGHT

"Involve staff for guidance."

Ongoing bullying, significant family concerns, emotional distress, questions beyond your role, or other sensitive disclosures should be shared with a ministry staff member. Stay kind and calm; do not feel pressure to provide counseling or make a ministry decision on your own.

RED LIGHT

"Get help immediately."

Possible abuse, threats of harm, self-injury, serious safety concerns, a medical emergency, or a student in immediate danger require urgent help through the church's approved response and reporting procedures. Follow emergency directions and any applicable legal reporting requirements. Never promise absolute confidentiality.

YOUR WEEKLY QUICK CHECK

BEFORE

- [ ] Have I confirmed when and where to serve?
- [ ] Do I know my role, team lead, and any updates?
- [ ] Have I prayed for the students coming tonight?

DURING

- [ ] Am I approachable, attentive, and present?
- [ ] Have I welcomed someone by name or helped someone connect?
- [ ] Have I communicated any concerns to the right person?

AFTER

- [ ] Have I finished my station's closing tasks?
- [ ] Have I communicated follow-up needs?
- [ ] Have I confirmed my next serving date?

COMPLETE LOCALLY

CAMPUS QUICK REFERENCE

CAMPUS / MINISTRY _____

MINISTRY NIGHT & LOCATION _____

ARRIVAL / HUDDLE TIME _____

STUDENT MINISTRY STAFF CONTACT _____

SUPPORT TEAM LEAD _____

CHECK-IN / NEW STUDENT PROCESS _____

SECURITY TEAM LEADER & CONTACT _____

ANYTHING MISSING? _____

QUESTIONS YOU MAY HAVE

Q **What if I can't serve one week?**

Communicate as early as possible using your campus's approved scheduling process. Do not assume your spot is covered until you have followed that process.

Q **What if I don't know the answer?**

It's okay to say, "That's a great question. Let me connect you with someone who can help."

Q **What if a student wants to talk about following Jesus or baptism?**

Celebrate their question and connect them with a Group Leader or ministry staff member who can walk through their next steps. Pray with them when appropriate.

Q **What if I notice a concern but I'm not sure how serious it is?**

Tell your designated staff or security contact promptly. It is better to communicate a concern than to carry it alone.

ONE STUDENT AT A TIME

One welcome.
One conversation.
One prayer.

A student's story can change through one conversation, one welcome, one moment of feeling safe, one invitation into community, or one prayer. The moments that feel small to us may be the moments God uses in a big way.

Thank you for helping connect students to Jesus and to one another.

SPACE TO THINK

NOTES


Southeast
Students
CONNECTING PEOPLE TO JESUS & ONE ANOTHER